Estelle El-Hai Word count: 729
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IT'S GREEK TO ME !

The reviews on the movie, "The Big Fat Greek Wedding" were not that great, but friends who had seen it told me how delightful it was, so I went with a few pals to view it. I, too, found it to be very entertaining, and it brought back several incidents of my past "Greek history".

Sam's mother, two of his sisters, and a five year old niece, were the only El-Hai's who traveled from New York to attend our wedding in Los Angeles. Although they are wonderful people, they stayed with us, in our home, for six weeks after our honeymoon !! My stubborn Greek father-in-law wouldn't attend any wedding because he didn't believe that rabbis should get paid for their services. But that's another story. Six months later, during the summer, we decided to drive cross-country, see the wonderful sights, and visit the rest of Sam's family in New York. Like the movie, the large family consisted of his grand- parents Ya- Ya and Papoo, more siblings, and jillions of aunts, uncles and cousins. A gala reception would follow our arrival, and I certainly wanted to make a good impression. To help bring that about, my dear husband taught me a lovely Greek phrase that I practiced over and over. He said that I would endear myself to the whole family if I expressed it with emotion. I visualized that tearful hugs of welcome would follow. What did I know!

The eventful day finally arrived and before the sumptuous meal began, Sam proudly introduced me and declared that I had become a Greek scholar and had a sincere wish to share. They all applauded as I stood up, and with arms outstretched proclaimed, "Tsa klahnes alla nichta!" Stark silence ... open mouths .... My surprise turned into bewilderment as the family then roared with laughter and slapped their knees. I looked at Sam who was sputtering into his glass of ouzo.

One of his sisters finally confessed that my dear spouse had taught me to say, how can I put it nicely?, "You should relieve yourself from gaseous pressures all night long!" Strangely enough, it did endear me to them.

The never-ending dinner that my wonderful mother-in-law, Sarina, prepared, was absolutely delicious. However, the chicken soup had what looked like mushrooms floating on top.

"Are these mushrooms in the soup Mom?", I queried.

"Eat, eat, I'll tell you later." , was her reply.

The mushrooms were creamy with a crunchy edge, and I later learned that they were a Greek delicacy; sliced chicken heads with a brain center. I have mastered many Greek dishes, excluding that one.

Ya Ya also wished to teach the newcomer a Greek thing or two. She served Sam and me her special Greek coffee, served in delicate demi-tasse cups. Not only was it my first cup of Greek coffee, it was my first cup of any coffee. The liquid was thick and sweet (glyco), and the few sips I enjoyed before I reached the "mud", were tasty. Ya Ya put the tiny saucer over the cup and quickly reversed it, to allow the grinds to drip to the small plate, forming various patterns in the cup. She repeated this procedure with Sam's cup. After a minute or two, the cups were set right-side-up so that our "fortunes" could be read. Ya Ya examined the patterns, and clapped her hands together, as she gazed upwards. She hugged us both, kissed our cheeks, and said in Greek, "One pattern; one heart!" It seems that Sam and I had almost identical
impressions. I quickly learned this maneuver, and together with a wild imagination and some "chutzpah", I have teased and fascinated many acquaintances. In fact, after reading a gentleman's cup, he asked me to advise him on stock options!

Within a few days, I'm expecting an exciting visit from my eleven year old granddaughter, Sarina, from Seattle. She is the easiest child

to plan meals for. Sarina loves all kinds of vegetables, salads, fruits,

(except mangoes), and doesn't have the usual hangups of many kids. When I asked her if she had any requests for meals, she replied, "I love your soups Bubby."

"Great! How about a hearty chicken soup?" I asked.

"That's fine with me Bubby, but please leave out the mushrooms."

"No mushrooms Sweetie. I promise."

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